

Discovery Call Script

A 30-minute structure for first calls with prospects. The goal is not to pitch — it's to diagnose. Prospects hire the freelancer who understood their problem best, not the one who talked most.

Before the Call (5 minutes of prep)

- Skim their website / product / social presence
- Write down one genuine observation (“I noticed your checkout flow has 6 steps...”)
- Decide your walk-away number — the minimum this project would be worth taking

Phase 1 — Frame the Call (2 minutes)

“Thanks for making time. Here’s how I like to run these: I’ll ask you some questions about what you’re trying to achieve, and by the end I’ll tell you honestly whether I’m the right fit — and if I am, I’ll follow up with a proposal within [2 business days]. Sound good?”

Why this works: You’ve just taken control of the process and promised honesty. Both are rare.

Phase 2 — Diagnose (12–15 minutes)

Ask these in order. Let silence do the work — don’t rush to fill pauses.

1. **“What prompted you to reach out now?”** (The word *now* is the key — it surfaces the real trigger and urgency.)
2. **“What have you already tried?”** (Reveals budget history and failed vendors — listen for why they left.)
3. **“If this project goes perfectly, what’s different for your business six months from now?”** (This is the outcome you’ll sell in your proposal — write down their exact words.)
4. **“What happens if you do nothing?”** (Quantifies the cost of inaction — useful later when discussing price.)
5. **“Who else is involved in deciding this?”** (Finds the real decision-maker before you write a proposal for the wrong person.)

Phase 3 — Budget (3 minutes)

Do not skip this. A call without a budget conversation is a coffee chat.

“So I can point us at the right kind of solution — do you have a budget range in mind for this?”

If they deflect (“What do you charge?”), anchor with a range:

“Projects like this typically land between [\$X] and [\$Y] depending on scope. Does that range work for what you had in mind?”

If their budget is under your walk-away number, say so kindly now — you’ll both respect the honesty, and they often come back later with real budget.

Phase 4 — Fit Statement (2 minutes)

If it’s a fit:

“Based on what you’ve told me, this is squarely the kind of work I do. The piece I’d focus on first is [their #1 pain]. I’ll send you a proposal by [specific day] with two options and exact pricing.”

If it’s not:

“I’ll be straight with you — I don’t think I’m the best fit for this, because [honest reason]. If it’s helpful, I can point you toward [alternative].”

Phase 5 — Lock the Next Step (2 minutes)

Never end with “I’ll send something over.” End with a scheduled event:

“I’ll send the proposal by [day]. Can we put 15 minutes on the calendar for [2 days later] to walk through it together?”

Proposals reviewed live close at a dramatically higher rate than proposals left to be read alone.

After the Call (same day)

- ☐ Send a recap email within 4 hours (use Email Script #2)
- ☐ Note their exact words for goals and pain — those phrases go in your proposal verbatim
- ☐ Calendar the proposal deadline you promised

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